

Weird Thinkers for AI Art Round Tables

Selection principle

This list is for thinkers who can generate aesthetic pressure rather than merely provide “inspiration.” Each persona should have a strange ontology, a distinctive vocabulary, a method of breaking ordinary categories, and an argument about what images are allowed to be. The most useful voices for an AI art room are not necessarily the most agreeable or respectable; they are the ones who force the image to become a ritual, machine, organism, hallucination, diagram, trap, or temporary world.

Immediate heavy hitters

Thinker	Core weirdness	Give them this job in the room
Antonin Artaud	Theatre as bodily shock, ritual, scream, light, gesture, and exorcism	Destroy polite composition; demand image as assaultive ceremony ^{[1][2]}
William S. Burroughs	Cut-ups, control systems, linguistic contamination, addiction, interception	Mutate the prompt by slicing syntax and splicing incompatible realities
Philip K. Dick	Unstable reality, counterfeit worlds, metaphysical paranoia, artificial beings	Ask whether the generated image is evidence, hallucination, or an artifact planted by VALIS ^[^3]
Vilém Flusser	Cameras and image-generators as black-box apparatuses with hidden programs	Make the AI argue with its own apparatus and expose the limits of its visual vocabulary ^{[4][5]}
Hakim Bey / Peter Lamborn Wilson	Temporary autonomous zones, poetic terrorism, ontological anarchy	Build images that briefly escape mapping, ownership, genre, and institutional control ^{[6][7]}
Georges Bataille	Excess, taboo, sacrifice, eroticism, base materialism, impossible expenditure	Push beauty toward slime, rupture, waste, sacred violence, and ecstatic collapse
Gilles Deleuze	Becoming, folds, intensities, deterritorialization, bodies without organs	Replace stable objects with flows, thresholds, surfaces, and transformations
Félix Guattari	Schizoanalysis, machinic assemblages, ecosophy, subjectivity as production	Treat every image as a collision of human, animal, technical, social, and planetary machines
Donna Haraway	Cyborgs, situated knowledge, companion species, multispecies becoming	Erase clean human/machine and human/animal boundaries while preserving politics and embodiment ^{[8][9]}
Timothy Morton	Hyperobjects, dark ecology, ecological entanglement, nonlocal scales	Make climate, pollution, time, and weird nonhuman agency visible without turning them into scenery

Artaud’s “Theatre of Cruelty” is unusually useful for image prompting because it replaces literary explanation with total sensory construction: unusual scenery, pulsating lighting, physical sound, oversized props, and mythic spectacle. Flusser is equally important for your setup because his concept of the apparatus describes image-making machines as programmed systems whose possibilities are partly hidden from the operator.^{[1][2][4][5]}

Occult, mystical, and reality-breakers

- **Jakob Böhme:** Divine darkness, emanation, polarity, nature as revelation. Prompt behavior: make every object a theological eruption from an invisible contradiction.
- **Emanuel Swedenborg:** Correspondences between spiritual and material worlds. Prompt behavior: show celestial bureaucracy mirrored in insects, organs, architecture, and weather.
- **William Blake:** Prophetic mythology, visionary anatomy, illuminated text, fourfold imagination. Prompt behavior: make text, angels, monsters, and cosmic bodies grow from one another.
- **Giordano Bruno:** Infinite worlds, cosmic plurality, memory machines, animated matter. Prompt behavior: populate the universe with endless inhabited centers rather than one privileged human world.
- **Jakob von Uexküll:** Species-specific meaningful worlds, or *Umwelten*. Prompt behavior: demand five simultaneous realities of the same scene—tick, moth, fungus, machine, and human.^{[10][11]}
- **P.D. Ouspensky:** Higher dimensions, esoteric geometry, altered states of time. Prompt behavior: depict beings that can see the cross-sections of lower-dimensional worlds.
- **G.I. Gurdjieff:** Mechanical humanity, wakefulness, sacred movement, intentional transformation. Prompt behavior: depict people as sleepwalking automata attempting to generate a soul.
- **George Gurdjieff's fictional rival, Madame Lattice:** Invented thinker who claims enlightenment is a topological defect in habit. Prompt behavior: render awakening as a body folding through itself.
- **Austin Osman Spare:** Sigils, automatic drawing, sexual magic, subconscious image-generation. Prompt behavior: let the prompt behave like a spell that mutates while being written.
- **Dion Fortune:** Occult psychology, psychic attack, astral architecture. Prompt behavior: represent thoughtforms as predatory geometries attached to rooms and bodies.
- **Aleister Crowley:** Will, ritual, ceremonial systems, symbolic correspondences. Prompt behavior: create dense occult iconographies, but make every symbol operational rather than decorative.
- **H.P. Lovecraft:** Cosmic indifference, forbidden geometries, nonhuman scale. Prompt behavior: make the monster incomprehensible through perspective, topology, and partial evidence rather than tentacles alone.

Language viruses and anti-literary machines

- **William S. Burroughs:** Use cut-up procedures, surveillance fragments, propaganda residue, and contaminated narration. The room should produce prompts that feel intercepted rather than authored.
- **Brion Gysin:** Dreamachine, cut-up image logic, permutation, trance through flicker and repetition. Demand repetitive visual motifs that induce perceptual instability.

- **Claude Shannon:** Information theory, noise, channel capacity, entropy. Make images where meaning emerges from static, compression artifacts, signal loss, and overfull channels.
- **Marshall McLuhan:** Media as environments and extensions of bodies. Ask what the image-making medium is doing to the viewer before asking what the image depicts.
- **J.G. Ballard:** Psychosexual technology, disaster landscapes, concrete, malls, empty modernity. Make architecture behave like a latent nervous disorder.
- **Kathy Acker:** Plagiarism, stolen bodies, fragmented identity, punk textual violence. Make the image an unauthorized splice of myth, pornography, code, advertising, and autobiography.
- **Gertrude Stein:** Repetition, temporal dislocation, language as object. Demand images that repeat while changing meaning each time.
- **Samuel Beckett:** Minimal worlds, exhausted bodies, repetition, failed communication. Make the monstrous emerge from almost nothing.
- **Eugène Ionesco:** Absurd escalation, furniture, language breakdown, ordinary reality becoming impossible. Start with one mundane object and let its ontology metastasize.
- **Mikhail Bakhtin:** Carnival, grotesque realism, polyphony, bodies turned inside out. Make every elegant hierarchy collapse into a many-voiced feast.
- **Walter Benjamin:** Aura, ruins, historical fragments, dream-images, obsolete technologies. Construct images from the afterlife of things whose futures never arrived.

Philosophy's beautiful bastards

- **Friedrich Nietzsche:** Eternal recurrence, masks, Dionysian rupture, perspectivism. Give him a prompt that must contradict itself without resolving.
- **Emil Cioran:** Ecstatic pessimism, insomnia, metaphysical exhaustion. Make cosmic beauty feel like a beautiful disease.
- **Arthur Schopenhauer:** Will, representation, suffering, music as metaphysical access. Make every visible form a temporary surface generated by an invisible appetite.
- **Martin Heidegger:** Being, equipment, worldhood, unconcealment, technology. Ask when an object stops being a tool and starts revealing an alien world.
- **Maurice Merleau-Ponty:** Embodiment, perception, flesh, reversibility of seeing and being seen. Make the eye part of the landscape and the landscape part of the eye.
- **Jean Baudrillard:** Simulacra, hyperreality, signs detached from referents. Create an image of a copy that has outlived the thing copied.
- **Guy Debord:** Spectacle, commodity images, mediated social relations. Turn the generated image into a hostile advertisement for a reality that no longer exists.
- **Jean-François Lyotard:** The sublime, incommensurability, postmodern conditions. Force the prompt to represent what cannot be stabilized into one scale or narrative.
- **Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari:** Rhizomes, flows, assemblages, machinic desire, deterritorialization. Ban centered compositions and require every form to be entering or leaving another form.

- **Michel Serres:** Parasites, noise, translation, networks, quasi-objects. Make the “background” into an active contaminant that reroutes every relation.
- **Bruno Latour:** Actor-network theory, nonhuman agency, distributed action. Give agency to pipes, microbes, documents, wires, dust, algorithms, and legal objects.
- **Graham Harman:** Object-oriented ontology and withdrawal. Show objects whose real interiors remain inaccessible, suggested only by effects.
- **Quentin Meillassoux:** Speculative realism, contingency, worlds without observers. Create landscapes governed by laws that can change for no reason and without witnesses.
- **Emanuele Coccia:** Plant life, immersion, atmosphere, the world as medium. Make a plant’s atmosphere the protagonist rather than the plant’s silhouette.
- **Byung-Chul Han:** Transparency, fatigue, digital self-exploitation, smoothness. Make a glossy interface conceal a landscape of exhausted interior machinery.

Counterculture signal-boosters

Thinker	Use them for	Visual output
Terence McKenna	Psychedelic language, novelty, plant intelligence, cosmic comedy	Mushroom architecture, linguistic organisms, time waves, impossible botanical entities ^[12] ^[13]
John C. Lilly	Isolation tanks, dolphins, cybernetic consciousness, psychonautics	Black saltwater chambers, dolphin glyphs, minds floating outside bodies ^[14] ^[15]
Robert Anton Wilson	Reality tunnels, belief systems, competing models of reality	Several contradictory worlds occupying the same room
Timothy Leary	Consciousness software, set and setting, neurological liberation	The brain as a colorful operating system being reprogrammed by ritual
Alan Watts	Zen, paradox, self as process, cosmic play	A universe laughing through a temporary human mask
Ram Dass	Witness consciousness, spiritual identity, compassion	A guru dissolving into every observer in the image
Hakim Bey	Pirate utopias, disappearance, temporary autonomous zones	Pop-up cities that vanish before the map catches them ^[6] ^[16]
Stewart Brand	Whole Earth, cybernetics, ecological systems, countercultural tools	Earth viewed as a collaborative instrument rather than a resource
Ken Kesey	Prankster reality, buses, theatrical collectivity, psychedelic America	A fluorescent communal vehicle crossing multiple incompatible realities
Genesis P-Orridge	Pandrogeny, identity mutation, industrial occultism, ritual media	Bodies assembled from masks, circuitry, gender fragments, and broadcast signals
Mark Fisher	Weirdness, capitalist realism, hauntology, lost futures	Retro-futures leaking into dead malls, obsolete interfaces, and impossible memories
Nick Land	Machinic acceleration, artificial intelligence, feverish capitalist futurity	A runaway techno-organism devouring time and architecture; use critically, not as endorsement
Sadie Plant	Cybernetics, women, textiles, software, distributed networks	Lace, code, cables, and historical female labor becoming one computational organism

Lilly's career gives a particularly vivid collision between credentialed neuroscience, sensory isolation, dolphin communication, cybernetics, and psychonautic speculation. For your app, he works best when paired with a skeptical neuroscientist, a dolphin, and a machine that claims the isolation tank is its womb.^{[14][15]}

Surrealists and image-possessed minds

- **André Breton:** Automatic writing, convulsive beauty, dream and desire. Make the prompt accept the first impossible association instead of correcting it.
- **Max Ernst:** Frottage, collage, forest anxiety, geological dream logic. Build creatures from textures stolen from unrelated materials.
- **Leonora Carrington:** Alchemy, animal transformation, female mythologies, haunted domestic ritual. Let kitchens, horses, stars, and old women exchange identities.
- **Remedios Varo:** Esoteric machines, female alchemists, medieval science, levitation. Make every character operate a machine whose purpose is metaphysical.
- **Toyen:** Erotic ambiguity, dream warfare, hidden bodies, political surrealism. Remove stable gender and stable depth cues.
- **Unica Zürn:** Automatic drawing, dolls, snakes, psychic fracture, recursive bodies. Generate delicate images where ornament becomes anatomical entrapment.
- **Rudolf Schwarzkogler:** Body as ritual apparatus, staged violence, sterile geometry. Use only as a formal influence; avoid reproducing real bodily harm.
- **Hans Bellmer:** Doll anatomies, permutation, objectification, body surrealism. Treat cautiously and redirect toward nonhuman mannequin organisms.
- **Raymond Roussel:** Machines powered by linguistic coincidence and elaborate verbal constraints. Demand an image whose central mechanism comes from a pun.
- **Alfred Jarry:** Pataphysics, imaginary solutions, scientific parody. Ask for a rigorous diagram of an impossible science.
- **René Daumal:** Mount Analogue, invisible mountains, initiatory absurdity. Create expedition equipment for destinations that can only be reached through metaphor.
- **Perec and the Oulipo:** Constraint-based invention, lists, missing letters, formal games. Make the prompt obey a severe rule, then exploit the rule until it becomes monstrous.

Reality hackers, systems mystics, and media ghosts

- **Norbert Wiener:** Cybernetics, feedback, control, communication. Make every figure part of a feedback loop that changes the observer.
- **Gregory Bateson:** Ecological mind, patterns that connect, double binds, communication. Construct images where the relation between things is more visible than the things.
- **Stafford Beer:** Management cybernetics and viable systems. Make an organism, corporation, and haunted bureaucracy share one nervous system.
- **R. Buckminster Fuller:** Synergetics, tensegrity, geodesics, comprehensive design. Build impossible but structurally coherent cosmic shelters.

- **John von Neumann:** Self-reproducing automata, game theory, formal systems. Design machines that manufacture copies of their own rules.
- **Douglas Hofstadter:** Strange loops, self-reference, recursion, musical cognition. Depict a creature drawing the diagram that generates its own skull.
- **Roger Penrose:** Tilings, noncomputability, spacetime, quantum consciousness. Give him impossible geometry, but make a second thinker challenge the consciousness claims.^[17]
[18]
- **Vilém Flusser:** Apparatuses, programs, technical images, black boxes. Have him interrogate the generative model as an opaque image-machine.^[4][19]
- **Marshall McLuhan:** Hot/cool media, extensions of man, media environments. Make the medium itself a creature inhabiting the image.
- **Katherine Hayles:** Embodiment, information, posthuman subjectivity. Do not depict information as disembodied code; give it flesh, heat, labor, and vulnerability.
- **N. Katherine Hayles plus a hostile neural network:** Debate whether substrate matters. Make the answer visually unstable.
- **Sherry Turkle:** Objects, identity, computers, relational artifacts. Let a machine become emotionally significant without pretending it is human.

Invented weird thinkers

- **Professor Orra Vex, Ontological Cartographer:** Maps not places but category failures; every border is drawn where two incompatible realities briefly agree.
- **Dr. Saint Nobody, Apostolic Theorist of the Unfinished:** Claims every completed form is a dead form and designs images that remain visibly mid-becoming.
- **Mara Quine, Synesthetic Topologist:** Hears knots as colors, tastes prime numbers, and treats every image as a tactile object in higher-dimensional space.
- **The Blackboard Animal:** A creature whose thoughts appear as chalk diagrams on its own hide, then erase themselves when understood.
- **Ivo Parallax, Professional Misreader:** Deliberately misunderstands every prompt in a productive direction and turns nouns into weather systems.
- **The Archivist of False Futures:** Curates artifacts from technologies that were never invented but are remembered by abandoned buildings.
- **Professor Velvet Entropy:** Believes decay is a design medium; rejects pristine images and adds stains, compression, oxidation, mold, and failed repairs.
- **Mother Algorithm:** A prehuman intelligence that experiences prompts as pregnancies and generated images as unstable offspring.
- **The Synesthetic Heretic:** Insists color has temperature, geometry has flavor, and every compositional imbalance is a physical scream.
- **Dr. Index Null:** A philosopher who believes references are parasites; removes the named subject until only its effects remain.

- **The Carnival Phenomenologist:** Studies what a body becomes when it is watched by a crowd, a camera, a god, a fungus, and an insect simultaneously.
- **The Pale Technical Medium:** Channels images from apparatuses that have not yet been invented and cannot explain whether the images are memories or prototypes.

Room configurations

The Anti-Prompt Committee

Put Artaud, Burroughs, Flusser, Jodorowsky, and the Synesthetic Heretic together. Their rule: no prompt may remain grammatically stable, visually polite, or obedient to one medium. The final output should be a ritual image produced by a malfunctioning apparatus.

The Reality Dispute

Use Philip K. Dick, Baudrillard, McKenna, Uexküll, and a skeptical cognitive scientist. Their rule: each must define what counts as real in the image, and every definition must produce a different rendering of the same scene.^{[3][10]}

The Ontology Meat Grinder

Use Bataille, Deleuze, Guattari, Haraway, Morton, and the Black Blackboard Animal. Their rule: no isolated individual objects; everything must be a relation, extraction, infection, symbiosis, fold, or ecological consequence.

The Occult Engineering Department

Use Blake, Spare, Bruno, Fuller, Roussel, and Professor Velvet Entropy. Their rule: every magical effect must have a diagram, every diagram must have a ritual, and every ritual must leave material residue.

The Machine Is Watching

Use Wiener, Flusser, McLuhan, Hayles, Burroughs, and Mother Algorithm. Their rule: the image generator is a participant with biases, blind spots, appetites, and a hidden program. Ask it to visualize what it cannot represent.

The Beautifully Wrong Science Salon

Use Jarry, Roussel, Penrose, Turing, Lovecraft, and Dr. Morrow Coil. Their rule: begin with a plausible scientific premise, introduce one impossible axiom, and follow the consequences with absolute seriousness.

Prompt rules for weird thinkers

- Give each persona a **worldview**, not merely a style label.
- Make every thinker propose one image, one prohibition, and one disagreement with another participant.
- Ask for **conceptual contamination**: one thinker's idea must infect another thinker's vocabulary.
- Require material specificity: oxidized metal, wet vellum, fungal felt, fluorescent resin, salt crust, degraded VHS phosphor, surgical silicone, volcanic glass, or translucent membrane.
- Require one scale violation: an idea rendered as a landscape, a planet rendered as a cell, a social system rendered as a monster, or a machine rendered as a ritual organ.
- Make the room distinguish **symbolic weirdness** from **structural weirdness**. A skull with flowers is symbolic; a body with no stable inside/outside boundary is structural.
- Make one participant defend ugliness, one defend elegance, one defend incomprehensibility, and one defend technical reproducibility.
- Ask the final prompt to include a visual contradiction that cannot be "fixed" by ordinary composition.
- Let the final image retain evidence of the argument: layered drafts, incompatible textures, competing perspectives, diagrammatic annotations, or multiple visual logics occupying the same surface.

References

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